

Suggested Answer Scheme

1. Is the world today a more dangerous place?

Analysis:

This question requires the student to compare dangers in the world today and in the past, how they have evolved vis-à-vis methods to contain or ameliorate them.

Clarification of terms:

- **Dangerous:**
 - Traditional threats: war/conflict stemming from ideological differences or territorial claims, use of nuclear power
 - Emerging threats: Terror attacks, lonewolf/copycat attacks, enhanced nuclear capabilities
 - Cyber threats: cyber-crime, cyber-bullying and cyber-terrorism, threats to privacy from governments and corporations
 - Global threats: climate change – damage to ecosystems & food supplies
- **More:** Threats have escalated (intensity), become more complex (nature) as compared to the past
- **Traits of 'the world today':** interconnected, technologically-driven, increased mobility

Possible Approaches:

1. The world today is a more dangerous place
2. The world today is not a more dangerous place

A. Yes, the world today is a more dangerous place

1. Conventional threats have persisted and become even deadly especially in the light of expanded nuclear capabilities and the frequency of terrorism.

- a. Nuclear-capable nations such as **India vs Pakistan** having border skirmishes and potential escalation of conflict, rogue nations such as **Iran** and **North Korea** who continue to defy international sanctions in their use of nuclear power
- b. **The Arab-Israeli conflict** continues unabated and is considered today as a volatile region where violence can quickly escalate
- c. Terrorism since the deadly 911 attack has taken a more sinister turn with increased lone-wolf attacks eg. the **2017 truck strikes on pedestrians in New York and Stockholm** by the Uzbeks. The ease of recruitment and self-radicalisation via online media platforms fuels anti-West terrorism not merely in the Middle Eastern regions but former Soviet republics.
- d. The rise of right wing populism as signalled by Trump and other victories in EU has led to a more dangerous world due to white supremacy movements and xenophobia.

Increased right-wing extremism, as seen in the **2019 Christchurch attacks**, are all evidence of a more dangerous world.

2. The emergence of new threats via technological platforms reinforces the reality that we are living in a more dangerous world, with the rise of a whole host of cybercrimes and harvesting of personal data.

- a. Online platforms such as **8chan** have increasingly become megaphones for mass shooters and a recruitment platform for violent nationalists, precipitating attacks such as the mosque killings in Christchurch, New Zealand and the synagogue shooting in Poway, California.
- b. Singapore, in spite of high levels of technological security, suffered its worst **cyber-attack** in July 2018 where hackers stole the particulars of 1.5 million patients by infiltrating the computers of **SingHealth**, the country's largest group of healthcare institutions. The hacking, which involved the theft of outpatient prescriptions that included Prime Minister Lee Hsien Loong, was carried out by what is believed to be a "well sourced" "state-sponsored espionage group".
- c. There have also been growing cases of **cyberbullying** and **sexual grooming** for which the young are particularly vulnerable. Philippines is particularly notable for its emerging cases of **cybersex trafficking**, where thousands of youngsters are at risk, some at the hands of their caregivers or volunteers. The highly sensational arrest of British paedophile Richard Huckle who posed as an English teacher and sexually abused some 200 children in Malaysia and authored a manual on how to target vulnerable children highlights how depraved and dangerous the world is today for young people, on top of the increased incidence of drug abuse, gangs, shootings and knifing incidents in schools.
- d. Besides cybercriminals, **large internet companies** such as **Facebook** have also added to the sense of uncertainty and fear that they have also been spying on and trying to manipulate their customers. Personal data harvested by Facebook was utilised by consultancy firm Cambridge Analytica to direct messages for political campaigns, most notably Trump's election victory and the Brexit vote.

3. New unprecedented global threats that directly affect human health and ecosystems have also made this world a more dangerous place.

- a. The rise of **super-pathogens** spreading quickly across our planet poses biological threats that have either brought fatalities or continue to endanger the world's population, including which include viral hemorrhagic fevers (eg. ebola virus), antibiotic-resistant microorganisms (eg. multidrug-resistant TB), SARS, MERS, various other influenza pandemics (eg. avian flu, swine flu) and the recent Wuhan coronavirus. Experts have warned the coronavirus may prove as deadly as the Spanish flu, which claimed 50million lives. The apparent lack of pandemic preparedness as claimed by experts also exacerbates the dangers faced by today's world.
- b. **Global warming** which causes extreme weather, rising sea levels and **threats to food supplies** is another major source of concern where increasingly alarming reports of melting polar ice and seemingly lack of concerted efforts have all contributed to an increasing sense of danger in today's world. Global warming affects the spread of

mosquito-borne infectious diseases, including malaria and dengue, beyond the tropics and undermines the rich biodiversity

B. No, the world today is not a more dangerous place

1. Many countries have come together in international and regional blocs to effectively mitigate some of these threats and dangers

- a. Despite the harsh exchange of words and sometimes bullets and artillery shells, India and Pakistan have not raised the nuclear option and are open to efforts from the US to ameliorate tensions
- b. China and the US have also done their part to **rein in North Korea** when its sabre-rattling gets too vocal or tries to expand its nuclear capability.
- c. There have been other victories which have given us hope that threats to the world will be effectively nipped, like **dismantling of ISIS** or even the killing of terrorist leaders like Osama bin Laden
- d. Where pandemics are concerned, countries have strengthened their **national health security capacities** and readiness to deal with such infectious disease outbreaks. This ranges from epidemic intelligence (event detection & verification), travel bans, contact tracing, quarantines, information management and dissemination.
- e. Public response measures across nations have also been strengthened, including social distancing and increased respiratory and handwashing hygiene.

2. The very same technology that engendered new threats has also empowered people to do something towards countering such threats and not be just helpless victims waiting for dangers to strike.

- a. When harnessed effectively, modern technologies have the ability to help us reboot the health of our nature and planet. **Remote sensing data** enables the detection of deforestation from palm oil expansion while drones and crowdsourcing help monitor forest health and detect illegal logging. The creation of the **Apps for Earth campaign** raised \$8 million and educated millions of people around the world about core conservation issues helps to foster a more engaged public that takes action against environmental threats that endanger the safety of the planet.
- b. Scientific advancements have facilitated the **development of vaccines**, such as the Ebola vaccine which were used extensively in 2018-19 under a compassionate use protocol. Just a month after the first case of the Wuhan coronavirus, Chinese scientists were able to **sequence the viral genome**, facilitating the ease of accurate diagnosis and increasing the hopes of finding possible vaccines. Technological tools, such as an open-access repository for genetic information, thus allows for scientists to unravel vaccines with unprecedented speed and openness.
- c. Where online technologies are concerned, activists such **as Greta Thunberg** inspired other students in US and Europe to stage school walkouts to drive home the message to the powers-to-be on the urgency of climate change.
- d. In the aftermath of horrific school shootings, one mother, Shannon Watts, decided to do something and started the **Moms Demand Action for Gun Sense** on social media in

the US. She soon had thousands of followers and women from across the country began reaching out to her about starting local chapters.

3. The perception of a 'more dangerous world' is fuelled by misinformation/ignorance and a primal instinct to gravitate towards more sensationalised fear-mongering news and headlines

- a. In 2001, psychologists Roy Baumeister, Ellen Bratslavsky, Catrin Finkenauer, and Kathleen D. Vohs published a paper: ***Bad is Stronger than Good*** which highlights the human predilection towards the bad, rather than searching out the good. The fact that people think that bad news is the whole truth when it is merely a small piece of a larger picture makes us susceptible to the erroneous view that the world is a worse or more dangerous place than before.
- b. Swedish academic and founder of the Gapminder Foundation also writes that people believe that it is a dangerous world because of ***selective reporting*** and a greater ***'surveillance of suffering'*** which creates an 'illusion of deterioration'
- c. The ***age of fake news*** or unverified claims circulating online also creates a negative culture of fear and paranoia and a mistaken belief that we are in a dangerous world. Some politicians also ***politicise this fear*** in order to swing public votes (eg. Trump's campaign statements that Mexican 'rapists' bringing 'drugs' and 'crime' to the US)

4. We must also remind ourselves that amidst all the seeming doom-and-gloom of a world becoming increasingly unsafe, our current existence can also be described as the pinnacle of development rather than a more dangerous world.

- a. There is room for cautious optimism as the unflagging human spirit have survived man-made threats like the two deadly World Wars and countless minor conflicts as well as overcome, or at least tame the worst of what Nature can inflict from Black Death to the smallpox and even Ebola.
- b. In times of need, history have shown us that the human race has shown the ability to rally together to overcome threats and challenges. The Montreal Protocol is a ready (but admittedly rare) example of how decisive and swiftly we can act together as a global community to close the hole in the ozone layer which threatened to cause cancer and other ills.
- c. In more recent times, countries like Costa Rica and New Zealand have voluntarily announced plans to be carbon-neutral or even carbon-negative without the need for coercive or punitive treaties.

Sample Paragraph:

More dangerous:

The world today, being interconnected and interdependent, is arguably more dangerous than before. Beyond conflicts and epidemics that have a spill-over or contagion effect on other nations, **technological platforms** have created a whole new realm of unprecedented threats in the form of cybercrimes. **[P]** Online platforms such as 8chan have increasingly become megaphones for mass shooters and a recruitment platform for violent nationalists, precipitating attacks such as the mosque killings in Christchurch, New Zealand and the synagogue shooting in Poway, California. **[EX]** There have also been growing cases of

cyberbullying and sexual grooming for which the young are particularly vulnerable. Philippines is particularly notable for its emerging cases of cybersex trafficking, where thousands of youngsters are at risk, some at the hands of their caregivers or volunteers [EX], a violation of trust and safety in a most vile and shocking form [EV]. Large-scale online data breaches on Yahoo, Adobe, JP Morgan Chase and SingHealth, where personal information of users were leaked [EX] aggravate the reality that the world is a more dangerous place, especially when these big IT giants and government agencies appear powerless to develop systems to protect themselves from such breaches [EV]. The fact that large internet companies such as Facebook and Google clandestinely harvest users' personal data and make them targets of political messages or advertising shows that we are living in a more dangerous world today as people are being monitored and manipulated in insidious ways [L].

Additional References:

1. <https://www.channelnewsasia.com/news/asia/philippines-child-sex-abuse-live-streaming-cybersex-exploitation-10769092>
2. <https://www.weforum.org/agenda/2018/08/here-s-how-technology-can-help-us-save-the-planet/>
3. <https://www.washingtonpost.com/science/2020/01/24/scientists-are-unraveling-chinese-coronavirus-with-unprecedented-speed-openness/>
4. <https://www.psychologytoday.com/us/blog/excellent-beauty/201607/is-the-world-more-dangerous-now-ever>
5. <https://cdl.ucf.edu/wp-content/uploads/2019/04/Factfulness-Hans-Rosling.pdf>

2. Is failure always a bad thing?

Clarification of Terms

Failure: the lack of success in doing or achieving something. May be explored in specific areas such as economic failure, failure in school, failure in business ventures and entrepreneurship, governmental failure etc.

Always: an absolute term that needs to be refuted. Provides no room for exceptions, i.e. when failure has been able to stimulate further growth and improvement, or made way for the insights gleaned from mistakes.

A bad thing: consequences that cannot be negated or ignored. Has a significant impact that results in some sort of suffering. Students should try to be specific about the types of impacts that may result.

Assumptions

1. That failure is usually and naturally deemed as an end in itself; there is unlikely any redemption or positive outcome that may arise from failure

Possible Approaches

1. Failure is largely a “bad thing” because it usually means consequences, but the absolute must be refuted
2. Failure usually means disappointment and consequences, but often enough, it can also lead to positive outcomes or learning.

Approach 1: Why failure is a bad thing:

1. No return or second chances, e.g. in areas of education, business entrepreneurship

One might easily argue that in many developed countries where education is the gateway to a future, there are high stakes placed on being able to advance continuously without any setback or failure in major examinations. Failing to do so would mean that one might be left behind or allowed a far slower rate of progression as compared to his peers, and ultimately this may result in not achieving success at the end of one’s education, or later on in life, due to missing timely opportunities or the resultant demotivation from failure.

Highly stratified countries such as Singapore, South Korea, Japan and Hong Kong are known to face stigmatisation when it comes to academic failure, because many in society see it as final, and unable to provide alternative avenues for survival.

- For example, in Singapore, secondary schools are very much stratified due to PSLE score-based admissions, and children who do not do well in the PSLE are unlikely to find themselves placed in a school with others from similar backgrounds and with similar problems. Many go on to struggle on at secondary school in the lower streams, where they suffer from self-esteem problems and stigmatisation in the Normal Technical stream. The 20% of students each year who fall into the Normal Technical stream typically only have access to an ITE education in their next step, which is not highly valued by employers.
- Meanwhile, students who do well make it into elite secondary schools and get to benefit from the high standards, more conducive environment and better social connections that come with mixing with others like themselves. As such, many of them go on to the junior college route which then leads more naturally to a university degree and consequently, a higher chance of success in life later on.
- The fact that suicide rates in Singapore doubled in 2015 to 27 cases amongst young children aged 10-19 due to academic stress and failure clearly shows the growing mentality that there is no rebound from failure. This has also been mirrored in Hong Kong, where there are similar calls to review the education system and the way failure is seen or judged, in order to reduce suicide rates amongst youth there as well.

Likewise in the business arena, those who try their hand at entrepreneurship find that oftentimes, meeting with failure means that there is no second chance for them, and they usually have to seek out a “safer” route thereafter for their livelihood. It is a luxury that only the minority or the rich can afford to face entrepreneurial failure and still have enough money to go on to a new venture or restart one’s business again.

- For example, only about 50% of businesses in the United States continue to survive after 4-5 years of endeavour, with the other 50% ending in failure within those few years. In Singapore, there is a deathly fear of entrepreneurial failure owing to small market size and high rental costs amongst a number of reasons, and the almost certain knowledge that one may never recover his losses, both in the monetary and time senses. As such, only 4 out of 10 graduates in Singapore are willing to consider starting up a business in their next ten years.

(Consider: Possible Rebuttal to the above point)

There are more inclusive definitions of success today, and we see these manifestations in the types of schools and educational routes offered to students especially in developed countries, as well as the celebration of people who make it in life one way or another, even without a proper or complete education.

Many developed societies have now reinvented ways of seeing and defining success even at a young age. Students are now given more leeway to explore alternative educational routes whilst pursuing their interests or passions, the latter of which could be seen as what defines them as successes in their own right, regardless of their academic potential.

- The Singapore Sports School and the School of the Arts were set up in 2004 and 2008 respectively, in a clear effort by the government to respect that students' success should not merely be defined by test scores and examination grades, but should extend beyond to their physical and artistic talents. This was also in recognition and response to the realisation that the world stage called for diversity and varied capacities from individuals, especially as we moved on to the 21st century.
- There are numerous examples all over the world of young entrepreneurs who have succeeded in making a name for themselves, one of which is Michael Dunlop, who started trading at only eight years old and sold Pokemon cards to friends. Due to his having dyslexia, and not being able to get support from teachers, he did not do well in school and finally quit school at the age of 16 to start up his own blog that went on to become very successful, called IncomeDiary.com, which dispensed advice to entrepreneurs and bloggers. Today, Dunlop earns a six-figure salary from his blog, despite not being able to do well academically.
- Fraser Doherty was only 14 when he began making homemade jams via his grandmother's recipe. His "SuperJam" business was booming by the time he turned 16. When a major U.K. supermarket asked to stock his products, he took out a \$9,000 loan and became a millionaire. His recipe books are also selling on Amazon.

The idea here is that whilst some may argue that failure is in itself, the point of no return, this may not necessarily be true if we go beyond to see that there are many avenues to carving a living for oneself, or perhaps even achieving great wealth and renown. Many successful entrepreneurs and/or businesses are largely self-made, and who were able to see and work to their advantage loopholes, gaps, or unmet needs in their environments, independent of their educational backgrounds or achievements.

2. Everlasting impacts that take a long time to alleviate or change, e.g. economic or government failure

Failure can be considered to be irredeemably damaging and have long-term consequences when it concerns issues with deep and wide-ranging impacts, such as in the case of economic failure or the failure to govern a country peacefully.

- For example, corruption, social division and money politics combined to create a state of strong instability in Thailand in 2014, where anti-government protestors thronged the streets to call for the shutdown of the then government, known as the “Thaksin regime”, with Yingluck Shinawatra in power at the time. Violence was also a real threat, with businesses grounding employees and embassies worried about a return of the 2011 rioting that saw storefronts burned to the ground, 100 people killed and about 2,000 injured during similar anti-government protests.
- The few years of political unrest and the failure of democracy took a heavy toll on the country’s investment, tourism revenue and economy. According to The Economist in 2014, incomes were also expected to fall by 7% due to the political instability in the country.

As such, if governments are unable to execute policy, law and order, or provide for their citizens in the multitude of ways they are expected to, such as to provide education, healthcare, and safety levels, this can result in dire consequences or a severe backlash from the citizens that bring the country to a standstill and cause widespread suffering.

Approach 2: However, failure can also be seen as a stepping stone to future success, and therefore not an end in itself.

1. Failure can stimulate creativity/invention/innovation in order to solve the problem.

There is the mistaken belief that failure does not occur to companies or people who do their work “properly” or are smart enough to avoid failure, since what we as consumers tend to see, are the final product. What we do not see is all the various stages before such innovations could emerge. Not all great work is produced instantaneously or on one’s first attempt. More often than not, a polished end product is the result of tremendous effort and revision over an extended period of time. Pulling things apart again and improving on mistakes are part and parcel of creation, and failure is no stranger in any industry.

- For example, widely successful and popular motion picture company Pixar public admitted that their earlier works were poorly made, and it was only through learning from mistakes and revisiting mistakes and failure that creativity was born. This is the case even for movies that they still make.
- As Ed Catmull, the president of Pixar, put it: “Early on, all of our movies suck. That’s a blunt assessment, I know, but I... choose that phrasing because saying it in a softer way fails to convey how bad the first versions of our films really are. I’m not trying to be modest or self-effacing by saying this. Pixar films are not good at first, and our job is to make them go... from suck to non-suck. We are true believers in the iterative

process - reworking, reworking and reworking again, until a flawed story finds its throughline or a hollow character finds its soul."

2. Failure forces insight and reflection into the experience and builds resilience.

Failure allows one to face up to reality, particularly one's weaknesses. One shapes up or seeks to pursue what one is truly good at. This argument goes for both businesses and individuals alike. Without the ability for trial and error, it would be difficult for most to identify what they would truly like or be fully in touch with the practicalities of the matter.

When businesses or individuals fail, they are forced to take a hard look at their systems and possible errors that led to their failure. This reflection or insight usually, more often than not, allows for reinvention of their methods and perhaps even creativity, as well as better understanding of their target market and their needs. It is only through failing that success can sometimes be born.

- For example, Dyson, a well-known premium brand of vacuum cleaners today, was not always a well-known name. In fact, it took Sir James Dyson 15 years and all of his savings to develop a bagless prototype that worked. He developed 5,126 prototypes that failed first.
- Conversely, companies that fail to change from within and keep up with the changes in the real world or industry face being outmoded, such as Nokia. The famous mobile-phone company that held the biggest market share up to 2007 fell and finally sold its handset business to Microsoft in 2013, because it failed to keep up with what the market needed, mainly in the software arena. In contrast, Apple and Android both recognised the changing forces and demands of the market, and developed both their software and hardware to meet it.
- JK Rowling, the famous author of the Harry Potter series, has openly shared about the insights and knowledge that she built from her significant failures in both her writing (her script was rejected countless times by publishers initially) and her short-lived marriage before achieving success-- "So why do I talk about the benefits of failure? Simply because failure meant a stripping away of the inessential. I stopped pretending to myself that I was anything other than what I was, and began to direct all my energy into finishing the only work that mattered to me. Had I really succeeded at anything else, I might never have found the determination to succeed in the one arena I believed I truly belonged. I was set free, because my greatest fear had been realised, and I was still alive, and I still had a daughter whom I adored, and I had an old typewriter and a big idea. And so rock bottom became the solid foundation on which I rebuilt my life."

Understanding therefore, that failure is not a permanent state, or a necessary end to things and prospects, is crucial. It can be used to garner courage and strength in the face of adversity if one is able to put aside negative and lesser emotions, and extract the learning lessons and soldier forward. Success is then not necessarily elusive or out of reach.

3. The prospect of failure keeps people on their toes and avoids complacency.

Failure does not need to have occurred for us to reap benefits from its mere concept, because we are all brought up to understand the consequences of not being able to do something properly, or to bring it to completion.

From an early age, in most developed societies, children are taught to understand the consequences of failing in examinations or tests, and lagging behind their peers. Extra curriculum, enrichment classes and other skills are part and parcel of warding off failure, and bringing us closer to success.

Likewise, in our adult life, we work hard at our jobs in order to keep them.

In previous paragraphs as mentioned, businesses have an even stronger imperative to steer clear of complacency. This extends not just to being able to read changes in their industry or target group, but also being mindful of their attitude towards working at building their business.

- E.g. as quoted from an interview with Nokia's previous CEO-- "The problem of Nokia, after all, seems frustratingly similar to those of many large companies such as Microsoft or Sony **who could not develop high quality innovative products fast enough to match their rising competitors.**

As the companies grew larger and richer, **each department became its own kingdom**, each executive a little emperor, and people were more concerned about their status and internal promotion than cooperating actively with other departments to produce innovative products rapidly.

This phenomenon is also known as silo politics, and spreads naturally and quickly like bad weeds in the garden. In other words, the whole became less than the sum of the parts... and they did this because of a fear of losing social status.... As a result.... **Nokia top managers kept believing the company was progressing well in matching Apple's iPhone while it was not."**

Recommended reading:

JK Rowling's speech to Harvard Graduates, about the benefits of failure and imagination:

<https://news.harvard.edu/gazette/story/2008/06/text-of-j-k-rowling-speech/>

3. 'Schools kill creativity.' To what extent is this true in your society?

Clarification of terms

- *Schools*: Formal education system found in schools (not 'education' in the informal sense of the term)
- *Kill*: Destroy, eradicate
- *Creativity*: Ability to think out of the box, create and innovate new ideas, challenging the status quo, sense of imagination and wonder, originality

Assumptions

Creativity and academic achievement are mutually exclusive.

Possible approaches

- 1) Schools kill creativity to a large extent in Singapore
- 2) Schools in Singapore don't kill creativity but actually help it to flourish

Schools kill creativity to a large extent in Singapore

1) Singapore's education system kills creativity because of how high stakes the system is, leading to an aversion towards risk and making mistakes. Because achievement in the education system is so intertwined with the measure of an individual's worth and success, there is hardly room to make mistakes and grow from them, which is an integral part of the creative process. As a result, both parents and students are risk-averse and find that the "safest" route to take is to do exactly what is expected, without deviation from the road most travelled.

- A 2015 article in the Straits Times reported that parents with primary school children have complained that primary school science teachers are too rigid in marking open-ended questions, and are emphasizing rote learning over the understanding of concepts. Apparently the children were told by their teachers to stick to model answers which use key phrases and words found in textbooks, in order to obtain full marks in assignments or tests. This creates an unhealthy learning culture where students expect their teachers to spoon-feed them with model answers even at higher levels of studies instead of them finding imaginative and original ways to solve their academic problems.

2) Singapore schools are also not a conducive place for creativity because it is organized primarily around academic achievement, to the detriment of other more "creative" pursuits. The education system in Singapore was specifically engineered to develop the only real resource that Singapore has – its people. Through the years, it has evolved and become stratified to take into account mainly academic achievement as a marker of this success. As such, the system is structured in a way that is not conducive for creativity to flourish, because it immediately limits the options of those who do not perform well in standardized tests and exams, and does not provide alternative routes that recognize different kinds of strengths.

- One common critique of the education system is in how it streams students according to academic ability, a pre-determined path that there is little to no recourse from. For example, because of the nature of the qualifications earned, an ITE diploma-holder will find the path to a university degree lengthy, tedious, and near impossible if they are not able to gain higher NITEC qualifications. This has been argued to pigeon-hole students and limit the number of alternative paths they can take.
- There are also longer term implications on the way society views more “creative” fields like the arts, design and media. The traditional notions of “success” in the minds of many Singaporeans still entail doing well in more academic subjects, eventually paving the way to a high-paying, well-respected job in medicine, law or engineering. As such, when children are told from a young age that these are the desired outcomes of their education, it can stifle other appetites for more creative pursuits.
- In an interview with the BBC, Apple Co-founder Steve Wozniak argued that a company like Apple could not have emerged in a country with a structured education system like Singapore. He was quoted as saying: “When you’re very structured almost like a religion... Uniforms, uniforms, uniforms... everybody is the same. Look at structured societies like Singapore where bad behaviour isn’t tolerated. You are extremely punished. Where are the creative people? Where are the great artists? Where are the great musicians? Where are the great singers? Where are the great writers? Where are the athletes? All the creative elements seem to disappear.”

3) Even when creativity is pursued in education, it is still restricted by the national obsession with testing and achieving visible results. While schools have moved to introduce programmes that push holistic education, creativity and critical thinking, the ethos of pragmatism still pervades our education system, leading to an outsized focus on ensuring that these programmes yield tangible results. However, placing such a focus on testing for results in this field can lead to the commodification of creativity, where it not allowed to flourish in a natural way, but is constricted by the need to “succeed” and “excel” in creativity.

- A common criticism of the Direct Schools Admissions (DSA) scheme, which aims to provide students with talents in sports or the arts an alternative entry to secondary schools and junior colleges, is that it creates a new rat race which requires students to do better than their peers across both academic and co-curricular markers. This results in a corresponding push from parents to enrol their children in a whole host of extra-curricular activities to “boost” their chances of gaining entry through the DSA. This arguably makes the achievement of creativity hollow because it is merely a means to an end.
- This can also be extended to more ‘informal’ school systems of the enrichment class industry. While faultless in helping children cultivate creativity, one might argue that the pressures of gaining “accreditation” in the competitive ABRSM piano certificates, passing through the “grades” of ballet examinations go against the spirit of creativity and freedom of expression, because its “success” is tied to “achievement” of a more materialistic goal.

Schools in Singapore don’t kill creativity but actually help it to flourish

1) Even in academic subjects, the education system in Singapore is shifting to incorporate more elements of creativity, critical and innovative thinking. Academic pursuits and creativity are not mutually exclusive, and practically speaking, one cannot be pursued at the

expense of the other. The education system in Singapore has recognized this, and strives to provide students the room to both be rooted in a strong academic core, while also cultivating an inquiring and creative way to problem-solve.

- This has manifested in the implementation of policies like the “21st Century Competencies” framework which aims to prepare students for the future through developing competencies that include “critical and inventive thinking.” This has led to the improvement in the quality of “non-academic” subjects like Art, Music and Physical Education through the training of more teachers and provision of more and better resources for these subjects that provide more room for creative development.
- Singapore’s students have also increasingly been ranked highly in assessments of problem-solving skills and innovativeness. In the 2014 Programme for International Student Assessment (PISA) problem-solving test, Singapore students came out tops, beating students from 43 other countries. This test utilized real-life scenarios and problems to test students’ adaptability to unfamiliar contexts in problem-solving. The results proved that more than being just rote learners, students of the Singapore system are increasingly being trained to apply creative and innovative thinking.

2) Singapore’s education system has evolved to recognize the value of creative pursuits and to give students specific platforms to cultivate it. Our government is very sensitive to the fast-changing times and has recognized that in our modern world and workplaces, the individual who is valued is one who is adaptable, innovative and creative. These structural changes herald a shift in societal mindsets towards the role of creativity and inventiveness in success in the modern world, and clearly demonstrate that the education system in Singapore is set to help creativity flourish in its students.

- Primary schools have also started carving out niches for themselves in areas of the arts, sports, music and information technology, running specialized programmes that give students more exposure to these fields that encourage creativity. These programmes underscore the fact that creativity need not come only in the form of the arts, but can be woven into other pursuits as well. The fact that schools now provide these programmes on a regular and structure basis bodes well for the development of creativity through schools.
- The Music Elective Programme (MEP) and Arts Elective Programme (AEP) which have been rolled out to schools since the 1980s have been recently enhanced with the addition of the Enhanced Music Programme (EMP) and Enhanced Art Programme (EAP), which provide a two-year rather than four-year course to provide added flexibility to students who wish to develop their creative and artistic talents. Students in the latter two courses will gain not just exposure to the O-Level syllabus for Art or Music, but also exposure to the arts and creative industries in the form of master-classes with artists and musicians, and studio sessions and visits by practitioners for authentic and relevant learning. They will also have opportunities to hold exhibitions and perform at concerts. These clearly provide specific and tailor-made education platforms for students to cultivate their creativity in a very modern and cutting-edge environment.
- There is also now a large range of alternative education routes for students who do not excel in the more traditionally academic sense. Schools like the School of the Arts have been around for more than 10 years, and the up-and-coming School of Science and Technology, Singapore University of Technology and Design, and even liberal arts college

Yale-NUS are testament to the changing education landscape that is taking into account the need for different kinds of academic excellence and multiple intelligences.

3) Singapore schools are constantly innovating and have evolved to adopt more creative teaching practices, which results in the cultivation of creativity not only in students, but also in the teaching force. The move towards a more holistic education system that encourages creativity has meant that the focus has shifted from content knowledge to methods of thinking and processing information. This necessitates that teachers be innovative in the ways they teach and not rely on “tried and tested” methods. As a whole, education in Singapore embraces creativity not just as something to be taught to students, but as a principle to structure the whole system by.

- A 2011 OECD report on the lessons that the United States could learn from Singapore’s high PISA scores found that a key component to Singapore’s success was the commitment to research and innovation in pedagogical practices. The ‘Thinking Schools, Learning Nation’ initiative that was piloted all the way back in 1997 led to a national education research agenda costing SGP 50 million (about USD 38 million). It piloted interventions to demonstrate how to move classrooms from a predominantly knowledge transmission model to a 21st century model where students engage in complex knowledge construction.
- The report also found that schools in Singapore make extensive use of international benchmarking to explore best practices and creatively adapt them to the local context. As a result, Singapore classrooms incorporate a wide range of pedagogical styles. Principals and master teachers are also encouraged to examine innovations in other countries and explore how they could be adapted for use in Singapore schools. A couple of years ago, a Washington Post reporter covered a visit by a group of Singapore principals to several schools in northern Virginia. “Why,” she asked, “since Singapore is best in the world on the TIMSS international mathematics and science assessments, was a group of Singapore principals visiting science classes in northern Virginia schools?” The Singapore response: “There is no perfect system in the world. There are pockets of excellence in many places; the key is how to adapt them to the local context and implement them well.”
- At the classroom level, it was emphasised in 2012 by then-Minister for Education Heng Swee Keat that students need to be taught to “discern truths from untruths, connect seemingly disparate dots, and create knowledge even as the context changes.” This move towards critical and inventive thinking on the part of students has triggered a change in the ways schools teach the syllabus. This includes experiential learning by bringing students outside the classroom, increasing termly assessment to include creative group projects, and using ICT to engage students. Students in general, find themselves more engaged in these forms of lessons, rather than conventional chalk-and-talk ones. They also become more inquisitive, generating a keener sense of interest in the subject matter.

4. How far do you agree that Singapore youth are ready for the challenges in today's world?

Analysis:

The 21st century presents a host of challenges that are drastically different from that faced in the 20th. The pace of change has accelerated to such an extent that it is difficult to properly plan for the future. In light of these changes – be it in technology, landscape of work, or lifestyles – it is increasingly pertinent that we identify the right skillsets or mind-set to survive the changes. Set in the context of Singapore, this reflects a need to understand the environment in which youth grow and develop, as well as how this environment shapes them to be equipped with skills and mentalities required for the 21st century.

Clarification of terms:

- Singapore youth: Youth can capture a wide-range of individuals from secondary school going students to fresh graduates from university who are just starting out at the workplace. According to the National Youth Council, youths are defined as individuals aged between 15 and 35 years.
- Challenges in today's world: Modern challenges that arise due to certain characteristics of modern times. For example, a fast paced world would present the challenge that individuals have to be able to react positively to changes. Note that these challenges need not be unique to modern times, and could also involve challenges becoming more challenging as a result of certain modern developments.

Possible Approaches:

1. Singapore's youth are ready to face the challenges in today's world.
2. Singapore's youth are **not** ready to face the challenges in today's world.

A. Singapore's youth are ready to face the challenges in today's world.

1. **Youth in Singapore are given broader and more holistic educational opportunities to equip them with the needed skills.**
 - a. Students in Singapore are often reminded of their role not just as Singaporeans, but as citizens of the world – particularly of a bigger Asian community. This has led to increased opportunities for youth to attend exchange programmes overseas, participate in overseas service learning expeditions, internships and leadership development programmes. Or example, the ASEAN Young Leaders Training Programme organised by the All-China Youth Federation (ACYF) exposed its participants to a deeper understanding of China and helped establish networks between China's and Singapore's youth. [Extracted from a speech by Minister Grace Fu]
 - b. Singapore ranked top in Asia and 5th among 35 countries in an index on how effective countries are in preparing youths for the future labour market. This index was compile

by The Economist Intelligence Unit, which highlights that Singapore's curriculum framework supports the development of skills such as critical thinking, collaboration, and global awareness.

2. The young in Singapore are more concerned about, and willing to take action for, social issues.

- a. "The emergence of e-commerce and the pervasive use of mobile devices, have made our youth hyper-connected and hyper-empowered" – Grace Fu, Minister for Culture, Community and Youth at the Youth Parallel Forum in 2019. These modern developments have enabled youth to be more open to new opportunities and gain a better understanding of the world they live in; this allows them – as they get "enabled by technology" to grow "exponentially compared to just a decade ago".
- b. After its introduction in 2018, more than 8000 youths have been engaged in Youth Conversations – a national engagement exercise that gives youths the opportunity to participate in discussions on issues proposed by them. These engagements have led to a greater awareness of the perspective of others in societies, and aided them to be more appreciative of what they had in common with other Singaporeans.
- c. Youth, such as Cai Yin Zhou who started the Back Alley Barbers or Sazzad Hossain who established the Social Development Initiative Academy, are well aware of the issues that are plaguing our local and international community today. Their awareness of these issues often translate into productive action to address issues. This is further exemplified by Ho Xiang Tian, a 23-year old founder of LepakinSG an environmental advocacy group, as well as many other youths who participated in a climate change rally in 2019.

3. Singapore's youth today are adept at problem-solving, which is crucial to survival in the modern world.

- a. Over the years, Singapore's youth have shown themselves to be amongst the best in problem-solving skills. In the 2012 and 2015 PISA assessment taken by students all over the world, Singapore came in top in problem-solving. According to a special advisor to the OECD, the performance of students in these assessments reflects that Singapore's youth are quick learners who are able to adapt to changing contexts. This is testament to how the young in Singapore are ready to tackle the vagaries of the modern world.
- b. Students from local universities – NUS, SMU, and NTU – often emerge top of the class in international problem solving competitions. In 2018, Singapore's team emerged champions out of 31 other competing countries and territories at the International Young Physicists' Tournament. This competition pit students' abilities to apply their learning through research and deal with queries brought up by competitors on the spot. Similar results were garnered in competitions around the world in Biology, Chemistry and Geography – to name some – where students often had to go well beyond their syllabus to solve problems that are novel to them.
- c. In 2020, a 17-year old Institute of Technical Education student, Tay Gao Jun, attained the top ethical hacking credential, the title of Certified Ethical Hacker Master, which is only held by 150 people in the world. Alongside him, another local polytechnic student had also previously earned this accolade. Earning this title tests an individual's abilities

to work through various scenarios using their own knowledge. By passing the tests and attaining the accreditation, they have demonstrated clear abilities to solve problems at the highest level.

B. *Singapore's youth are not ready to face the challenges in today's world*

1. Singapore's youth may be perceived to lack resilience in the face of modern challenges.

- a. A survey conducted in 2016 by the National Youth Council reflected that youth in Singapore are worried about the future and the challenges they will face as adults, highlighting that they were not confident of being able to deal with these challenges. This reflects a high degree of emotional tension among the youth, due to, according to the Chief Executive Officer of NYC, having to come to terms with navigating between the temptations that social media offers and the realities of life.
- b. According to the Samaritans of Singapore, between 2018 and 2019, there was a rise in the number of suicides by 10 percent, with a spike in cases among teenage boys. It was suggested in a report by Channel News Asia that this was due to the lack of resilience in facing new social challenges and pressures.

2. The culture of mollycoddling in Singapore has resulted in youth becoming too caught up with themselves (self-absorbed) and unable to keep up with the demands of the working environment.

- a. In a nationwide survey conducted in 2019, it was found that many viewed millennials – those aged 19 to 36 – to be 'impatient, overconfident and materialistic'. In the same survey, they were also ranked the lowest for 'taking ownership for work' as a generation. This perception is also held by the millennials themselves, with only one-fifth of millennials surveyed thinking that their generation as disciplined and almost 85% thinking of them as impatient and want for instant gratification.
- b. The pervasive use of social media – which tends to display information according to the user's preferences – creates a new challenge for youth as there is increased tendency to be caught up in filter bubbles and echo chambers. This creates a situation where youth may become less engaged and interested in taking ownership in society. [According to a speech by Grace Fu]

3. The exposure received by students in school may not be relevant to the challenges youth will face in today's world.

- a. A survey conducted by Milieu Insight, an independent Singapore-based research company, found that young adults who have just started work for a few years did not really feel that their school education had equipped them well for the workforce as compared to students who were still schooling. Accordingly, this may be due to the great amounts of disruption to work and industries in the 21st century, rendering current content and skills taught less relevant by the time the youth are ready to work.
- b. In a 2018 survey conducted by the National Youth Council, 7 in 10 Singaporean youths reflected that they were not sure that their education would prepare them sufficiently for entering the workforce.

Sample Paragraph:

Singapore's youth are ready to face the challenges in today's world as can be seen from their concern and action for a myriad of issues that plague our society today. [P] Singapore's hypoconnectivity to the internet has enabled youths to be aware of many issues that are faced by local and global governments. From domestic issues such as casual racism – as suggested by a 2019 IPS survey – to global issues such as climate change, youths here have shown that on top of this awareness they are willing to face the challenges head-on and address them. [Elab] For example, the Back Alley Barbers was an initiative started by local youths to provide free haircuts to low-wage migrant workers in Singapore, while the Social Development Initiative Academy was set up to help the same group of workers to improve their skills and integrate better into Singapore's society. Other local initiatives such as LepakinSG or the congregation of youths in Singapore's inaugural climate action rally in 2019 reflect that youth here are unafraid of modern issues, and instead they are ready to take them head-on. [Ex] While the above might seem like they are isolated instances of over-achieving youth, this general willingness to step up and engage with the problems of today's world can be seen [Ev] in the active participation of youths in the Youth Conversation – a platform for youths to speak directly to representatives of the government on issues proposed by the youths themselves. [Ex] All this clearly reflects that they are ready for – and already engaging with [Ev] – the challenges in today's world. [Link]

Note: There are instances where there are overlaps in the different components of EEEL – this is natural.

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5. Can the media be relied upon to tell the truth?

Clarification of terms

- The media: The entire media industry – its operations and its products. This refers to traditional media (the news, television, radio) and new media (e.g. Internet-based media like social media, online news platforms)
- Relied upon to tell the truth: depended on to be an objective, reliable, accurate source of information

Assumptions

We expect a basic level of truth and accuracy from the media.

Approaches

- 1) Yes, the media can be relied upon to tell the truth.
- 2) No, the media largely cannot be relied upon to tell the truth.

Yes, the media can be relied upon to tell the truth.

1) The media industry has its own code of conduct to report the truth. A cardinal principle of the media industry, especially the news media, is to get the facts right and report them accurately. Journalistic codes of conduct, many of which were developed in the early 20th century, are drafted into the mission statements of various media outlets and always include the principle of accuracy and truthfulness. These principles hold journalists and media producers to account within a broader framework of media ethics, which helps us to rely on them to tell the truth.

- The Society of Professional Journalists (SJP) in the United States declares ‘Seek Truth And Report It’ as one of their guiding principles, where journalists are expected to take responsibility for the accuracy of their work, verify information before releasing it, and use original sources where possible.
- Many countries have criminalized defamation (the communication of a false statement that harms the reputation of an individual, business, product, group, government, religion or nation) and this has made it even more imperative that the media industry abides by the standards of journalistic integrity that are expected of them. Avoiding libel or defamation lawsuits is arguably a good deterrence against using the media for untruthful or inaccurate reporting.

2) The media today takes on many forms and has many different gatekeepers, making it easier than ever to check the reliability of the content that is broadcast. Unlike in the past where media outlets were the gatekeepers of news, people now have greater access to a myriad of different information sources thanks to the democratization that has taken place with the Internet and social media. News breaks much more quickly on social media platforms like Twitter than on news channels because of the speed the Internet affords, thus people can access real-time and unfiltered access to the facts of a news story. This puts greater pressure on the media to ensure that what is reported is accurate and can stand up

to public scrutiny. There is also a greater pressure on advertising media today to ensure that they present realistic and truthful portrayals of their products.

- In 2014, Target came under fire for a poorly Photo-shopped image that depicted a swimsuit model with a thigh gap that extended into her pelvis. Netizens were quick to point out the inaccuracy and a debate about companies' role in perpetuating negative body image was quickly ignited, prompting Target quickly apologize and pull the image from their site.
- The ease with which individuals in democratic states have access to a variety of media sources and their increased ability to make their own informed judgments on issues refutes the belief that the media can conceal information from the masses. This is reinforced by the fact that the world has become more globalised and interconnected and sees greater levels of media education and literacy. The public is now more sceptical of news information and more empowered to pick out media bias and falsehoods.

3) As the media is increasingly shaped by users themselves, the ethos of the media has evolved to become more investigative in nature rather than solely driven by political and economic interests. Thus there is a greater likelihood for truer and more realistic content.

Traditional media outlets are often bound by bureaucracy and have their agendas shaped by the people who control them. Co-opting news from various user-generated sources like Twitter can also make the content reported by the media even more comprehensive and objective.

- The prominence of 'whistle-blower' platforms such as Wikileaks implies that the media has increasingly become a means of exposing confidential information which concealed truth from the public, such as government and corporate misconduct.
- The International Consortium of Investigative Journalists (ICIJ) has made waves for its publication of the controversial Panama Papers, which detail financial and attorney–client information for more than 214,488 offshore entities. These included the information of the personal finances of a huge swath of the global elite, bringing to light their personal wealth and potentially illicit financial activities as they sought to evade taxation and conceal corruption. The ICIJ spearheaded the investigation based on a tip from an anonymous individual, helping to reveal the truth behind the financial activities of some of these elites and push for greater transparency.
- Another trend would be the rise of social documentaries that criticise or reveal the 'truth' about government policies or trends, egs. Michael Moore's documentaries such as *Fahrenheit 9/11*, *Bowling for Columbine* & *Sicko* which uncover the nature of terrorism, youth violence and the state of healthcare in the world today respectively.
- The rise of citizen journalism spearheaded not just from the grassroots but from media outlets themselves speaks to the growing base of user-generated content that is aimed at helping the media enhance its news stories. GuardianWitness, the citizen journalism section of UK-based newspaper The Guardian lets users contribute content via "Assignments" (based on topics given weekly by the editor), "Live News Tie-Ins" (where readers can contribute videos and commentary on breaking stories and events) and "Open Suggestions" (where users suggest newsworthy topics and ideas for stories). These not only democratizes the news-making process, but it also

takes place in a regulated framework of the traditional news media which keeps in check the range of contributions from the public.

The media largely cannot be relied upon to tell the truth.

1) The media industry is often driven by commercial interest that is at odds with objective reporting. When profit-maximization is the ultimate end goal, the media has to resort to various means and ways of attracting the largest possible readership or viewership. This results in the objectivity and truthfulness of the news possibly being distorted through both sensationalism and censorship. The editorial bias in sensationalised or biased media shows up in the language used in headlines, the selection and placement of photos, the omission of information, and the extensiveness of coverage.

- Academic studies surveying key media outlets such as Washington Post and NY Times have shown that journalists who are more 'liberal' tend to reflect these liberal attitudes in their coverage of controversial topics, pushing news coverage in a more liberal direction, and in so doing, 'misleading' or 'swaying' their readers to their points of view. It becomes evident that news stories are narratives, that carry implicit attitudes or messages rather than purely information and facts.
- Media outlets in the West have been quick to jump on the bandwagon of sensationalizing the various horrific attacks by the Islamic State even further, stoking fears of further attacks and in the process mischaracterizing Muslims. While sentiment of condemnation of ISIS is justifiable, this has also led to the knock-on effect of increased Islamophobia in Western Europe and across America. Many accounts have surfaced of Muslim Americans being discriminated against in stores, on airplanes and in schools due to an unbalanced portrayal of their religion in the news.
- Tabloid newspapers and magazines are an age-old example of sensationalism in the media, where headlines often play up dramatic and even fictional stories regarding celebrities in order to tap on the public's fascination with drama and ensure higher readership. From Brad Pitt and Angelina Jolie getting divorced, Prince William and Kate Middleton expecting twins, Katie Holmes being addicted to drugs... the litany of false "news" stories dominates our news-stands causing a warped perception of the lives of these celebrities and casts aspersions on their characters.

2) The increasing prevalence of media conglomerates (institutions which control a large number of media companies), also plays a part in skewing public opinion and knowledge.

The biases of these conglomerates shape the perspective and tone that their news outlets adopt. This is increasingly problematic as media conglomerates also gather political clout.

- Italian media tycoon and former Prime Minister Silvio Berlusconi is often held up as an example of the detriments of the concentration of media ownership and increase in censorship due to existing conflict of interest. Berlusconi controlled 90% during his term as Prime Minister, which was widely found to bolster his political control during his various terms as Prime Minister. He was also criticized for the passage of laws that ensured that he retained control of the huge stakes he held in the Italian media, resulting in a stark lack of plurality of voices in the media.

- The American news media has undeniably become polarised along partisan lines, with outlets like Fox News and MSNBC becoming synonymous with Republican and liberal political views respectively. The increasing alignment of these news outlets along party lines obscures the full picture of American politics from the public, and makes it more likely that viewers will be exposed to subjective accounts of political happenings.
- Corporate interests can also impinge upon the neutrality of the news being reported – larger networks such as NBC, CBS, and ABC, are owned, funded, and controlled by large corporate conglomerates and international banking interests, which filter out news that does not fit their corporate agenda (Eg. Coverage of BP Oil spill, SIA infighting played down in Straits Times, Straits Times releasing series of extensive book reviews featuring PAP publications, such as ‘Men in White’ & ‘Hard Truths’)

3) In certain contexts the objectivity of the media can be controlled and dictated by the governments of the countries they operate in. The media is regarded as the ‘Fourth Estate’ that acts as a check and balance to political powers; as an extension of the freedoms democracy offers, the free press is meant to serve the interests of the public by providing information that is objective and not tainted by the perspectives of those in power. However in its operation, the press can be controlled and manipulated by frameworks put in place by the government to suppress the “truth” and silence alternative voices.

- A commonly cited example is Singapore, where the government owns Singapore Press Holdings, the conglomerate that operates most of the media outlets here. The government has put into place various laws setting up ‘out-of-bounds’ or ‘OB’ markers around issues pertaining to race, religion and politics. The official justification is for the securing of Singapore’s social cohesion, but the government has also come under fire because this has also come at the cost of policing people with contrary political views and dealing harshly with them. Local political science academic James Gomez has argued that this has led to the creation of a “suffocating environment” of “self-censorship”, which distorts the reality that should be presented in the press.
- An extreme example of media censorship can most popularly be found in North Korea, where even radio and television sets are pre-set to receive only government frequencies and sealed with a label to prevent tampering with the label (it is illegal to receive transmissions from outside of North Korea). Internet access is also largely unavailable in the country, and the small number of computers that do have access are located in universities, monitored strictly, and connected to the country’s own network ‘*Kwangmyong*’. As a result, citizens are granted access only to the government’s sanitised and controlled version of “truth”.
- The Great Firewall of China: Chinese censors have a blacklisted keywords list, eg. Tiananmen Square, Human Rights, Liu Xiaobo) and such posts, as well as users’ accounts are blocked if they appear online.
- Cuba is famous for imprisoning independent journalists, outlawing expressions of dissatisfaction or disagreement with government policies or practices, and forbidding clandestine printing (disseminating independent information).

4) With the proliferation of user-generated content empowered by social media, the media landscape has come to be populated with a noisy and unregulated melange of voices and opinions that can obscure truth. While social media has given greater voice to the common man, this has also meant that consumers of media have to sift through the subjective accounts of events and experiences that populate our social media feeds. Citizen journalists have been criticised for reporting on “news” without proper journalistic training or without being held to journalistic codes of conduct which affect the objectivity and quality of their reporting.

- Singaporean bloggers Yang Kaiheng and Ai Takagi ran afoul of the law in Singapore recently for their posts on their site ‘The Real Singapore’ that falsely alleged that a Filipino family had created a commotion during the Hindu Thaipusam festival. They were charged with inciting racial hatred in Singapore while attempting to increase viewership and thus generate advertising revenue.

5) The media is also a powerful tool of manipulation that can be used to propagate wrong and even harmful viewpoints.

- ISIS is infamous for using the media as a platform to spread their terrorist agenda, promote self-radicalisation and attract new recruits (“Terror Marketing” – those with pornographic attraction to violent scenes are energised by the videos). Their savvy use of new media has drawn much attention as they have not only successfully intimidated people by sowing fear, but they have portrayed themselves as peaceful and deeply religious, with their lifestyles often depicted with a strong theme of ‘family’ and ‘community’. These have led to their successful recruitment of jihadists from countries far and wide, and sown suspicion and prejudice of otherwise peaceful and orthodox Muslims. These point to the power the media can have in obscuring truth when it is put in the hands of people who are not bound by ethical codes of conduct.
- There are many subtle ways of ‘concealing’ the truth, such as the gatekeeping bias (embargoing certain information as seen in the case of the Sanlu Milk Incident before the Beijing Olympics, the coverage of the burning of Qurans in the Iran base camp), deliberate positioning of news articles (to direct reader’s focus to one type of news over another), use of passive sentence structure (“US soldier kills children” vs “Children killed”), play of headlines (junior reporters cover the articles while senior writers choose the headlines) etc.

6. 'Education should be concerned with development rather than achievement.' Is this true of your society?

Clarification of terms:

- *Education*: The act or process of imparting or acquiring general knowledge, developing the powers of reasoning and judgment, and generally of preparing oneself or others intellectually for mature life.
- *Development*: The growth of an individual in multiple dimensions – cognition, emotion, morality, aesthetic appreciation, social skills etc.
- *Achievement*: The focus on external accolades or markers of success, primarily grades, as opposed to the inner attributes of an individual
- *Rather than*: This implies that development is preferable to achievement (Note: Good scripts must explicitly *compare* development vs achievement rather than list characteristics of either term)

Assumptions:

- Singapore's education system tends to focus more on achievement rather than development, possibly to the detriment of the individual and society.

Approaches:

- Yes, education should be concerned with development rather than achievement.
- No, education should be concerned with achievement rather than development.

No, education should be concerned with achievement rather than development

1. The overriding goal of education is achievement so as to ensure that all individuals are **trained in the requisite knowledge and skills in a systematic and quantifiable way that would make them most useful and productive to the economy** (principle of employability)
 - Academic achievement is the most quantifiable way of measuring teaching outcomes and forms the key performance indicator of Singapore's education system. Its grades-centred formula, which permeates every aspect of its education model, from the transcripts of students to the work review forms of education officers, allows for very focused and quantifiable targets that sees tangible results.
2. **The focus on achievement is what ensures Singapore's consistent success in the academic arena on the international stage.**
 - Due to this focus on achievement, Singapore's education system is held up as a model for other countries.
 - Singapore boasts one of the highest literacy rates around the world and is internationally recognised for its high-quality curriculum. A focus on achievement has led to strong programmes in Math, Science, and languages, with Singapore students coming out tops consistently in international tests. Singapore's world-leading, achievement-focused education system was amongst those picked out for commendation by the British education minister Michael Gove in 2010.

3. The focus on achievement is aligned with Singapore's meritocratic ethos, **fostering healthy competition that leads to the cultivation and selection of the best and most talented individuals** who can steer the country in key fields, be it politics, education or the legal system.
- The success of Singapore as a modern economy is premised largely on the country's meritocratic model in education, which focuses on rewarding those with the highest academic achievements.
 - Students are regularly pegged according to their ability throughout their school life during major national examinations at Primary 6, Secondary 4 and Pre-University, determining their admission into elite schools or neighbourhood ones, or into different programmes and streams (such as the Gifted Education Programme, Integrated Programme, Express, Normal Academic and Normal Technical streams). This system of filtering allows the government to identify the best and most able, retaining these talents in the talent pool of civil service through a whole host of attractive scholarships.
4. **Focusing on 'development' rather than 'achievement' can result in an education system that is overly indulgent, dampening performance and motivation levels unnecessarily in school.**
- When schools choose merely to develop their students and this 'development' is vaguely or unsatisfactorily defined, what results in a system that lacks rigour and stringency, producing lackadaisical students who do not strive for success.
 - British state schools have been portrayed in national newspapers in recent years as failing their brightest students due to a prevalent culture of "low aspirations". David Laws, UK's Minister of State for Schools and the Cabinet, commented that a lack of academic ambition and "depressingly low expectations" are holding back students in many parts of the country, hampering their potential and causing them to shy away from top universities and high-flying jobs.
 - The US faces a declining university graduate rate, and some commentators have attributed this problem of 'downward mobility' (i.e. graduate parents, non-graduate children) to the education system's lack of focus on achievement. Due to an absence of motivation and declining family incomes, US graduates have been declining as compared to the country's Asian and European counterparts.

Yes, education should be concerned with development rather than achievement

Singapore should adopt a more inclusive philosophy of education as its current overarching emphasis on scholastic achievement is outdated and myopic, one that neglects the holistic development of a child.

- Singapore's educational paradigm should shift from producing workers to staff the economy to uncovering the inner potential of individuals and nurturing their distinctive talents.
 - Prominent educational theories in the late 20th century focus on the extensive range of intelligences or skills that an individual can exhibit (eg. Howard Garnder's Theory of Multiple Intelligences), which Singapore schools should try to encourage.
 - Singapore should move away from using the tried-and-tested way of teaching - eg. rote learning, exam-oriented cramming – in order to get the best possible academic

results. Instead, it should consider the varied pedagogical methods to engage the child in learning (eg. kinaesthetic learning, meta-cognition, learning through art - LTA), allowing the child to learn and develop through a multitude of ways.

A focus on development rather than achievement allows Singapore to **address the current pitfalls of its education system**, which have surfaced because of an excessive focus on achievements and external accolades.

- A developmental model in education encourages educators to instill **morality and compassion** which are arguably lacking in the Singapore education system.
 - The rise of misbehaving scholars in recent years points to the fact that the Singapore system rewards academic strengths but neglects a focus on character development. Jonathan Wong, a Ministry of Education scholar, was awarded a teaching scholarship in spite of a suspicious moral background. He was caught peeping at girls at a nearby school and was eventually arrested as an undergraduate at York University for the possession of hardcore child pornography that rated 4 on the Copine scale, an act that shocked the British authorities and repulsed Singaporeans who criticised the scholarship screening process and the nation's almost exclusive focus on grades. Moreover, the unapologetically brazen attitude of NUS law scholar Alvin Tan who posted sexually explicit videos of himself and his girlfriend shows how the Singapore scholarship boards and education system may have placed an inordinate emphasis on grades as an eligibility criteria, forgoing other traits such as moral responsibility and accountability.
 - Singapore students tend to lack avenues for learning compassion for others, with many jumping on the community involvement programme bandwagon for selfish personal reasons, such as dressing up one's resume or to fulfil a school requirement. The fact that community service plays such a small role in the education system shows that the Singapore education system needs to focus more on development, to nurture citizens who are less insular and self-centred, addressing the rising social problem of apathy and 'nimbyism.'

A developmental model of education helps to remove the **psychological pressures and insecurities** that come from excessive competition.

- The performance mindset that has been inculcated in many Singaporean children prevents them from trying new things because of a fear of failure. Statistics have shown that Singaporean students, although high-achievers in examinations, are less likely to ask questions, experiment with learning methods, due to the ingrained pressure to excel.
- National surveys have consistently showed that Singaporean students dread examinations in schools, with local newspapers featuring "ways to beat the PSLE blues" and rising incidence of students who are diagnosed with performance anxiety and depression. Removing the stigma of failure through a focus on development may reduce such emotional pitfalls.

A focus on development rather than achievement helps to recapture a love for learning and cultivate the internal growth of an individual that has been slowly eroding in this competitive academic climate.

- Singapore would do well in emulating Nordic methods of education in its system, which encourages students to love learning by encouraging them to learn from their natural environment and at a slower and more reflective pace.
 - For children, the love for learning is encouraged early through child-directed play and game play rather than performance-driven enrichment classes in reading and arithmetic which Singapore kindergartens are starting to specialise in. For older students, this love for learning is cultivated through hands-on learning, excursions, self-reflection, work experience, and ample opportunities for social interaction.
- Singapore should try to integrate student development theories popularised in Europe into its education to allow for students to understand themselves better and to engage more deeply with the world around them.
 - Person-Environment: Showing students the relationship between the individual and the environment, or Humanistic Existential: Understanding concepts of freedom, responsibility and self-actualization by encouraging self-disclosure, self-acceptance and self-awareness.

Focusing on development allows for Singapore students to have the necessary range of skills (some of which are not necessarily measurable in nature) and equip them for the real challenges in a 21st century world.

- In addressing the limitations of the current education model, Singapore's Minister for Education, Heng Swee Keat, said that the focus of education should be "less about content knowledge" but "more about how to process information," pointing to the fact that academic achievement in the conventional sense may not as crucial as it was in the past.
- There is also a need to cultivate 'soft skills' such as *emotional literacy* or *emotional intelligence*, which involves the ability to manage one's emotions and perceive and empathise with the emotions of others in Singapore students. *Social intelligence* is the ability to navigate and negotiate relationships with others. This cluster of soft skills, which include social graces, communication, friendliness, and optimism, characterize successful relationships with others and are just as essential as hard skills in one's profession and in life.

Cultural literacy, or the familiarity with and ability to understand the idioms, allusions, and informal content that create and constitute a dominant culture and *civic literacy*, or the knowledge of how to actively participate and initiate change in one's community and the greater society, are two key areas that Singapore students should strive to grow in. This is especially so in a world that is increasingly cosmopolitan and has a greater number of needs that the next generation of Singaporeans can be more empowered to address.